news globally. The brutality against the Buddhist community in Myanmar was excessive even by the standards of the junta. This could have negative implications for the legitimacy of the regime both internally and externally. Economically, businesses were hurt by the upheaval and tourism suffered considerably. Many business elites were unhappy with the way the regime handled the crisis. This lack of confidence among the business elites and clergy could have potential ramifications. Finally, an economy already suffering from the fuel hike of August was further damaged.

FROM MAN-MADE DISASTER TO NATURAL DISASTER: CYCLONE NARGIS

During May 2 to 3, 2008, Myanmar was devastated by a category-four cyclone. Named Nargis, this cyclone was the worst natural disaster in the recorded history of Myanmar. The storm with 200-mile winds carved a path of destruction through the Ayeyarwaddy delta, as well as Yangon and parts of the Mon state. Literally hundreds of villages were instantaneously leveled and the agricultural lands lay in ruin. The actual death toll may never be known, but most estimates put the number around the 140,000 mark. An additional 2.4 million citizens were affected by the loss of homes or livelihood. The post-Nargis joint assessment (PONJA) puts the number of displaced at 800,000. The infrastructure of the areas hit was obliterated. Electricity, communications, transportation, education, and health care networks, all sustained massive damage.

The damage to the economy was compounded by the fact that the Ayeyarwaddy delta is the main food-producing area in Myanmar. Additionally, Yangon is the industrial and commercial center of the country. PONJA estimates that the economic loss is valued at 4 billion dollars, which is 21 percent of national gross domestic product (GDP). For the Ayeyarwaddy area, it is 74 percent, while in Yangon the estimated GDP loss is 57 percent. Economic rehabilitation will take years even with extensive external assistance. The potential for political and social upheaval will increase as citizens move to less vulnerable areas. Furthermore, pressure on the government increased as more and more citizens fell below the subsistence level.